

Keyboard Shortcuts — Detailed Lecture Notes

JKSSB Computer Awareness

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21.1 How to read a keyboard shortcut

A keyboard shortcut is a key, or a combination of keys, that performs a command directly without opening a menu. Shortcuts save time and reduce the need for the mouse, and they are a favourite topic in the JKSSB Computer Awareness paper because the answer is a single exact letter or key. In a combination written with a plus sign, such as **Ctrl+C**, the plus means: hold the first key down, then press the second key. You do not type the plus sign. Where three keys are written, such as **Ctrl+Shift+N**, hold the first two and tap the third.

Definition (Keyboard shortcut). *A key or key combination that runs a command directly — the same command a menu offers — so the user reaches it from the keyboard instead of with the mouse.*

The keys used to build combinations are called modifier keys. They are **Ctrl** (Control), **Alt** (Alternate), **Shift**, and the **Windows (Win)** key. A modifier key does very little on its own; it changes what the next key does. The **function keys F1** through **F12** run along the top row of the keyboard and are usually pressed on their own, without a modifier.

Key	Full form	Main role
Ctrl	Control	Acts on content: copy, cut, paste, save, find.
Alt	Alternate	Acts on windows and menus: switch, close.
Shift	Shift	Changes what is typed or selected; builds ranges.
Win	Windows key	Opens or controls system features: desktop, Explorer, lock.
Fn	Function (laptop)	Gives a second job to the F-keys on many laptops.

A practical split helps memory. The **Ctrl** combinations mostly act on *content* — copying, cutting, saving, finding. The **Alt** combinations mostly act on *windows* — switching and closing. The **Windows** key opens or controls system-level features such as the desktop, File Explorer, and the lock screen. Function keys are single keys whose job depends on the application that is active.

Most shortcut letters are chosen to be easy to remember. **C** stands for Copy, and **X** looks like a cross over the text, so it stands for Cut. **V** sits next to X on the keyboard and stands for Paste. **Z** is Undo and **Y** is Redo, the two editing-history keys. **A** is All (Select All), **S** is Save, **P** is Print, **F** is Find, and **H** opens the find-and-replace box. Learning the letter is more reliable than memorising a list, because the letter usually hints at the command.

21.2 Copy, cut, and paste

The three most common shortcuts form the clipboard group. The **clipboard** is the temporary holding area in memory where copied or cut items wait before being pasted.

Shortcut	Action
Ctrl+C	Copy the selected item; the original stays where it is.
Ctrl+X	Cut the selected item; the original is removed.
Ctrl+V	Paste the copied or cut item at the current position.

Definition (Clipboard). *A temporary area in the computer’s memory that holds text, images, or files after they are copied or cut, until they are pasted.*

The distinction to hold is that **Copy** and **Cut** both place the selection on the clipboard, but only **Cut** removes the original. A question that offers **Ctrl+C** and **Ctrl+X** as two options is testing exactly this difference: **Ctrl+C** leaves the original in place, and **Ctrl+X** does not. **Ctrl+V** only reads the clipboard; it never decides whether the item was copied or cut.

Example 21.2.1. *A candidate reads, “Which shortcut copies selected text without removing it from its original place?” The answer is Ctrl+C. Ctrl+X also puts the text on the clipboard, but it deletes the selection from the document, so it does not satisfy the phrase “without removing it”.*

21.3 Undo, redo, and select all

Three Ctrl shortcuts control the editing history and the current selection.

- **Ctrl+Z** — Undo the last action. It steps backward through recent changes.
- **Ctrl+Y** — Redo the action that was just undone. It steps forward again.
- **Ctrl+A** — Select All the content of the current window or document.

Undo and redo are a matched pair and must not be swapped. **Ctrl+Z** reverses a change; **Ctrl+Y** reapplies a change that was reversed. **Ctrl+A** does not select one word; it selects everything that can be selected in the current context. In MS Office the redo key is **Ctrl+Y**; a few non-Office programs use **Ctrl+Shift+Z**, but for this exam the standard answer is **Ctrl+Y**.

21.4 Save, print, find, and replace

These four shortcuts cover saving a file and working with text inside it.

Shortcut	Action
Ctrl+S	Save the current file.
Ctrl+P	Print.
Ctrl+F	Find (open the search box for text).
Ctrl+H	Replace (find a word and substitute another).

Find and **Replace** are near neighbours. **Ctrl+F** only locates the search text and highlights it; **Ctrl+H** opens the find-and-replace function, which can also change every occurrence to a new word. Similarly, **Ctrl+S** saves and **Ctrl+P** prints; the two are often offered together as distractors. **Ctrl+S** does not print, and **Ctrl+P** does not save.

Example 21.4.1. *A user types a report and wants to change every occurrence of the word “received” to “recd”. **Ctrl+F** would only find the word and stop there. The correct shortcut is **Ctrl+H**, which opens **Replace** and lets the user substitute the new text, one occurrence at a time or all at once.*

21.5 Alt-key combinations

The Alt key builds the window-management shortcuts.

- **Alt+Tab** — Switch between open windows or running applications. Repeatedly pressing Tab while holding Alt cycles through the open windows.
- **Alt+F4** — Close the active window or application.

On the desktop with no application window active, **Alt+F4** opens the shutdown or sign-out dialog. The concept to keep clear is that **Alt+Tab** *switches* between windows and does not close any of them, while **Alt+F4** *closes* the active window. A common wrong answer reverses the two. Note that **Alt+F4** closes the whole window; saving the file is still the job of **Ctrl+S**.

21.6 Function keys

A function key is a single key, F1 to F12, on the top row of the keyboard. Its action depends on the application that is running. For the exam, four function keys are high-yield.

Key	Standard action
F1	Help.
F2	Rename the selected file or folder (for example in File Explorer).
F5	Refresh the window or folder; in PowerPoint, start the slide show from the beginning.
F7	Spelling and grammar check (in MS Word).

Definition (Function key). *One of the keys F1 to F12 on the top row of the keyboard, whose effect is decided by the active application rather than by a fixed system command.*

In **PowerPoint**, F5 starts a slide show from the beginning and **Shift+F5** starts it from the current slide. In **Windows**, on a folder or desktop, F5 refreshes the view. F7 in MS Word launches the spelling and grammar check. A documented JKSSB item asked the key that starts a slide show from the beginning, and the answer was F5 (PYQ WO 2026 Q80, provisional key).

Example 21.6.1. *A candidate sees four keys: F1, F2, F5, F7. If the stem asks for Help, the answer is F1; for Rename, F2; for Refresh or slide show, F5; for the spell check, F7. Read the stem’s verb first, then pick the key that matches that verb.*

The table below fixes the near neighbours that JKSSB likes to mix. Each row is one function key; the middle column is its job; the last column is the trap (the job a careless candidate might wrongly attach to it).

Key	Correct job	Common wrong answer
F1	Help	Rename or Refresh
F2	Rename a selected file or folder	Help or New
F5	Refresh; start slide show	Spell check or Save
F7	Spelling and grammar check	Slide show or Help

21.7 Windows-key shortcuts

The Windows key (the key with the Windows logo) builds system-level shortcuts.

Shortcut	Action
Win+D	Show the desktop (minimise all open windows).
Win+E	Open File Explorer.
Win+L	Lock the computer.

Mnemonic: **D** for Desktop, **E** for Explorer, **L** for Lock. These three are system shortcuts, not content shortcuts, so they do not depend on which file is open. **Win+D** does not delete files, and **Win+L** does not shut the computer down; it only locks the session, and the user must sign in again.

The **Shift** key is a modifier too. It produces capital letters and the upper symbol of a key, and **Shift+Click** selects a range of items between two clicks. **Shift+F5** starts a PowerPoint slide show from the current slide. On its own with a letter, Shift does not save, close, or print; it changes what is typed or selected.

21.8 Other high-yield keys

The shortcuts above are the core of the lesson. A few adjacent keys and combinations appear often enough in Office documents that they are worth learning alongside them.

Shortcut / key	Action
Ctrl+O	Open an existing file.
Ctrl+N	Create a new file (new document or window).
Ctrl+W	Close the current document or window.
Ctrl+B / Ctrl+I / Ctrl+U	Bold / Italic / Underline the selection.
Esc	Cancel the current action or close a dialog.
Delete	Delete the selected item; in text, erase forward.
Backspace	Erase the character to the left of the cursor.
Home / End	Move to the start / end of the line.
Ctrl+Home / Ctrl+End	Move to the top / bottom of the document.
Page Up / Page Down	Move up / down one screen.

Two cautions. First, **Ctrl+O** opens and **Ctrl+N** creates; do not confuse the two. Second, **Ctrl+W** closes a *document*, while **Alt+F4** closes the *window or application*; in a browser, **Ctrl+W** closes the current tab.

21.9 Special keys that stand alone

A few keys send a command on their own, so they are never written with a plus sign. They are not combinations, but they are learned together with shortcuts.

Key	Action
Enter	Confirm a command or start a new line.
Esc	Cancel the current action or close a dialog.
Tab	Move to the next field, cell, or control.
Caps Lock	Toggle capital letters on or off.
Backspace	Erase the character to the left of the cursor.
Delete	Erase the selected item, or the character to the right.
Insert	Toggle Insert and Overtyping modes in text editors.
Home / End	Move to the start or the end of the current line.

Caps Lock and **Shift** both produce capitals, and this is a common confusion. Caps Lock changes every letter until it is switched off again, while Shift changes only the key pressed at that moment. **Delete** removes the selection or the character ahead of the cursor; **Backspace** removes what is behind the cursor.

21.10 Shortcuts in the office desktop workflow

A short walk-through on the office desktop ties the keys together. A clerk opens an existing letter with **Ctrl+O**, types the body, and underlines a heading with **Ctrl+U**. The heading is copied with **Ctrl+C** and pasted elsewhere with **Ctrl+V**; a wrong sentence is removed with **Ctrl+X**. A mistake is reversed with **Ctrl+Z**. The clerk searches the letter for a name with **Ctrl+F** and changes an old address to a new one with **Ctrl+H**. The finished letter is saved with **Ctrl+S** and printed with **Ctrl+P**. While the letter is open, the clerk switches to the spreadsheet with **Alt+Tab**, and when the letter is done, the window is closed with **Alt+F4**. Later, **Win+D** shows the desktop, **Win+E** opens File Explorer to find last month's folder, and **Win+L** locks the machine before the clerk steps away. This single sequence uses almost every shortcut in the lesson, which is why a scenario item is easy to build from it.

21.11 Exam retrieval and common confusions

Seven distinctions prevent most errors on this topic.

1. **Ctrl+C** copies and keeps the original; **Ctrl+X** cuts and removes the original. Do not treat them as the same command.
2. **Ctrl+Z** is Undo; **Ctrl+Y** is Redo. Reversing this pair is a common wrong answer.
3. **Ctrl+F** is Find; **Ctrl+H** is Replace. Find only locates; Replace also substitutes.
4. **Ctrl+S** is Save; **Ctrl+P** is Print. Save stores the file; Print sends it to the printer.
5. **Alt+Tab** switches between windows; **Alt+F4** closes the active window.
6. **F1** is Help, **F2** is Rename, **F5** is Refresh or slide show, and **F7** is the spell check (TRAP-32). Do not move a job from one key to another.

7. **Win+D** shows the desktop, **Win+E** opens File Explorer, and **Win+L** locks the computer.

Example 21.11.1. *An item asks which key is used to check spelling and grammar in MS Word. Trace the function keys: F1 is Help, F2 is Rename, F5 is Refresh or slide show, F7 is the spelling and grammar check. The answer is F7. If the stem instead asked for Rename, the answer would be F2, and if it asked for Help, the answer would be F1.*

21.12 Quick-reference sheet

Keep this single table for last-minute revision. It gathers every shortcut in this lesson.

Shortcut	Action	Shortcut	Action
Ctrl+C	Copy	Ctrl+S	Save
Ctrl+X	Cut	Ctrl+P	Print
Ctrl+V	Paste	Ctrl+F	Find
Ctrl+Z	Undo	Ctrl+H	Replace
Ctrl+Y	Redo	F1	Help
Ctrl+A	Select All	F2	Rename
Alt+Tab	Switch window	F5	Refresh / slide show
Alt+F4	Close window	F7	Spell check
Win+D	Show desktop	Win+E	File Explorer
Win+L	Lock computer	Shift+F5	Slide show from current

Exercises

1. State the action of Ctrl+C, Ctrl+X, and Ctrl+V.
2. Distinguish Ctrl+Z from Ctrl+Y, and Ctrl+F from Ctrl+H.
3. What do Alt+Tab and Alt+F4 do, and how are they different?
4. Give the standard action of F1, F2, F5, and F7.
5. What do Win+D, Win+E, and Win+L do? What does Shift+F5 do in PowerPoint?
6. Why is the plus sign in **Ctrl+C** not typed by the user?

Solutions

1. Ctrl+C copies the selection (the original stays); Ctrl+X cuts it (the original is removed); Ctrl+V pastes the copied or cut item at the current position.
2. Ctrl+Z undoes the last action, while Ctrl+Y redoes the action that was undone. Ctrl+F opens Find, which only locates text; Ctrl+H opens Replace, which can also substitute new text for the found text.
3. Alt+Tab switches between open windows or applications without closing any of them; Alt+F4 closes the active window or application. One switches, the other closes.
4. F1 is Help; F2 renames the selected file or folder; F5 refreshes the window (or, in PowerPoint, starts the slide show from the beginning); F7 runs the spelling and grammar check in MS Word.
5. Win+D shows the desktop, Win+E opens File Explorer, and Win+L locks the computer. Shift+F5 starts a PowerPoint slide show from the current slide.

6. The plus sign is only a way of writing the combination. It means “hold the first key, then press the second”; it is not a character to be typed.